

Academic Writing & Assignment

Week 3: Lesson 3



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

- So far this week, we have looked at essay structure, topic sentences and cohesion.
- Today, we are going to focus on argumentation.



How effective is the argumentation in this paragraph? Answer the questions on the right.



Globalization is usually seen as positive. Everyone agrees that nowadays the interaction between individuals, regions and nations is easier and faster than before. Some of the advantages of globalization are the increase of free trade between nations, the increased liquidity of capital, allowing investors in developed nations to invest in developing ones, the global mass media which ties the world together, the increase in flow of communications that allows vital information to be shared between individuals and corporations around the world, and the greater ease and speed of transportation of goods and people. All these benefits of globalization in markets have been made possible because of the existence of different organizations such as the World Bank, the World Trade Organization and the International Monetary Fund, which were created in favour of trade liberalization.

What is the argument in this paragraph?

What evidence is provided?

Is the evidence convincing? Why/Why not?

How effective is the argumentation in this paragraph?



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Globalization is usually seen as positive. Everyone agrees that nowadays the interaction between individuals, regions and nations is easier and faster than before. Some of the advantages of globalization are the increase of free trade between nations, the increase in international trade, the increase in international investment, the increase in international migration, the increase in international tourism, the increase in international communication, the increase in international cooperation, the increase in international understanding, the increase in international friendship, the increase in international peace, the increase in international justice, the increase in international harmony, the increase in international unity, the increase in international solidarity, the increase in international brotherhood, the increase in international sisterhood, the increase in international love, the increase in international peace, the increase in international justice, the increase in international harmony, the increase in international unity, the increase in international solidarity, the increase in international brotherhood, the increase in international sisterhood, the increase in international love.

This statement is not very convincing:

- It might not be true that 'everyone agrees'.
- Instead of saying 'everyone' it would be better to cite a specific source.
- Instead of just saying 'interaction...is easier and faster than before' it would be better to give cite statistics to demonstrate this. Alternatively, the sentence could be omitted given it says something that is obvious and doesn't add much to the argument.

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This statement is not very convincing. The sentence list four advantages of globalisation but doesn't go into any detail/depth or provide any specific evidence/examples.

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Is there a
concluding
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This is not a very effective concluding sentence. The paragraph is about the 'positives' of globalisation, not what has made globalisation possible. This would be better as part of a new paragraph.

Is there a concluding sentence?

corporations around the world, and the greater ease and speed of transportation of goods and people. All these benefits of globalization in markets have been made possible because of the existence of different organizations such as the World Bank, the World Trade Organization and the International Monetary Fund, which were created in favour of trade liberalization.

How effective is the argumentation in this paragraph? Answer the questions on the right.



Globalization has delivered economic benefits by fostering trade and investment. For instance, China's integration into the World Trade Organization (WTO) in 2001 significantly boosted its economy. By opening up to global markets, China saw an explosion in exports, particularly in manufacturing, which led to an average annual GDP growth rate of around 9% from 2001 to 2011. This rapid growth lifted over 800 million people out of poverty, as noted by the World Bank. Similarly, India's economic liberalization in 1991, which included reducing trade barriers and attracting foreign investment, resulted in a surge of FDI, particularly in the technology and services sectors. Companies like IBM and Microsoft invested heavily in India, contributing to the growth of its IT industry, which now accounts for more than 7% of the country's GDP. These examples illustrate how globalization can lead to substantial economic benefits such as poverty reduction and industrial growth (Bhagwati, 2004 & Sachs, 2005).

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ε This is quite convincing – it contains detail & specificity. It could be improved with a more specific reference i.e. when did the World Bank 'note' this?

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This is also quite convincing – again it contains detail & specificity BUT it could be improved with a reference – where do these statistics come from?

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This is quite effective – it sums up what the paragraph is about and contains a citation to literature.

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Is there a concluding sentence?



Stephan Toulmin (1958) provided a 6-part model of argumentation which has been very influential and can be used a tool for evaluating and developing arguments.

According to Toulmin, all arguments contain:

1. A claim (the main argument).
2. Grounds (evidence and facts that support the claim).
3. A warrant (the implied or explicit assumption that links the grounds to the claim).

Example



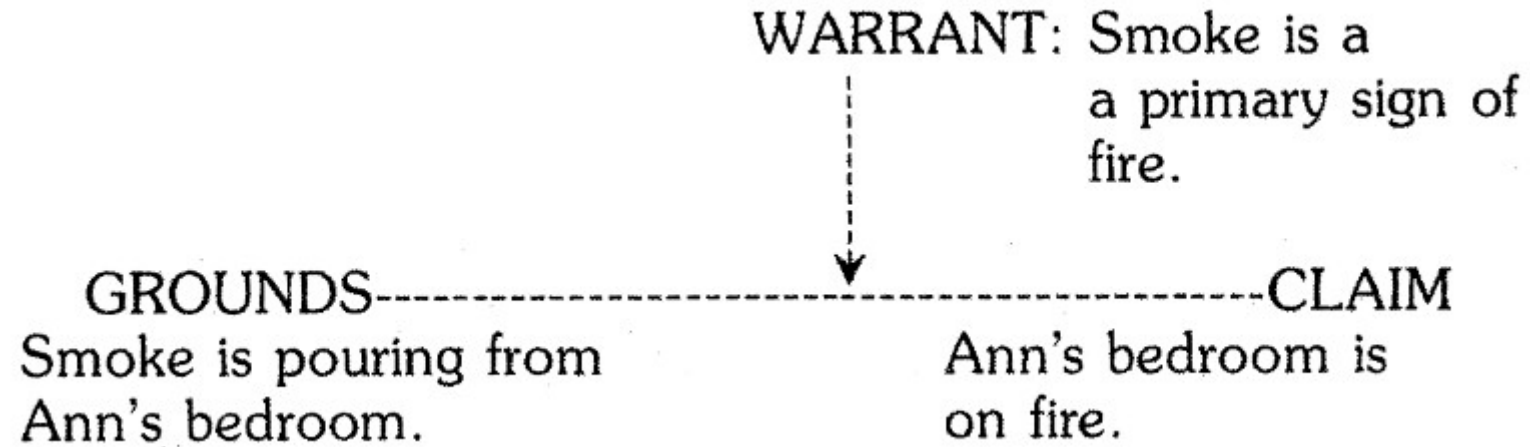
Grounds: *Smoke is pouring from her bedroom.*

Claim: *Anna's bedroom is on fire.*

Warrant: *Smoke is a primary sign of fire.*



Example



An argument can be criticised:

- ✓ If the grounds are incorrect or weak.
- ✓ If the warrant linking the grounds and argument is not robust.

Look at the sentence below:

Around 47% of London is green space making London a great city to live in.

1. What is the argument?
2. What are the grounds for the argument?
3. Are the grounds true?
4. What is the (implied) warrant?
5. Is the warrant robust?

Your turn



Answer these questions and then tell your group about your claims, grounds and warrants?

- Is social media harmful?
- Have we achieved gender inclusivity and equality?
- Should we be concerned about falling birth rates in some countries?

In addition to a claim, grounds and warrant, Toulmin says arguments can also contain:

- Backing (additional support of the warrant. In many cases, the warrant is implied, and the backing provides by giving a specific example that justifies the warrant.)
- A qualifier (this acknowledges that a claim may not be true in all circumstances using words like “may”, “some,” and “suggests”)
- A rebuttal (an acknowledgement of another valid view of the situation)

Example



Grounds: *Smoke is pouring from her bedroom.*

Qualifier: *So chances are...*

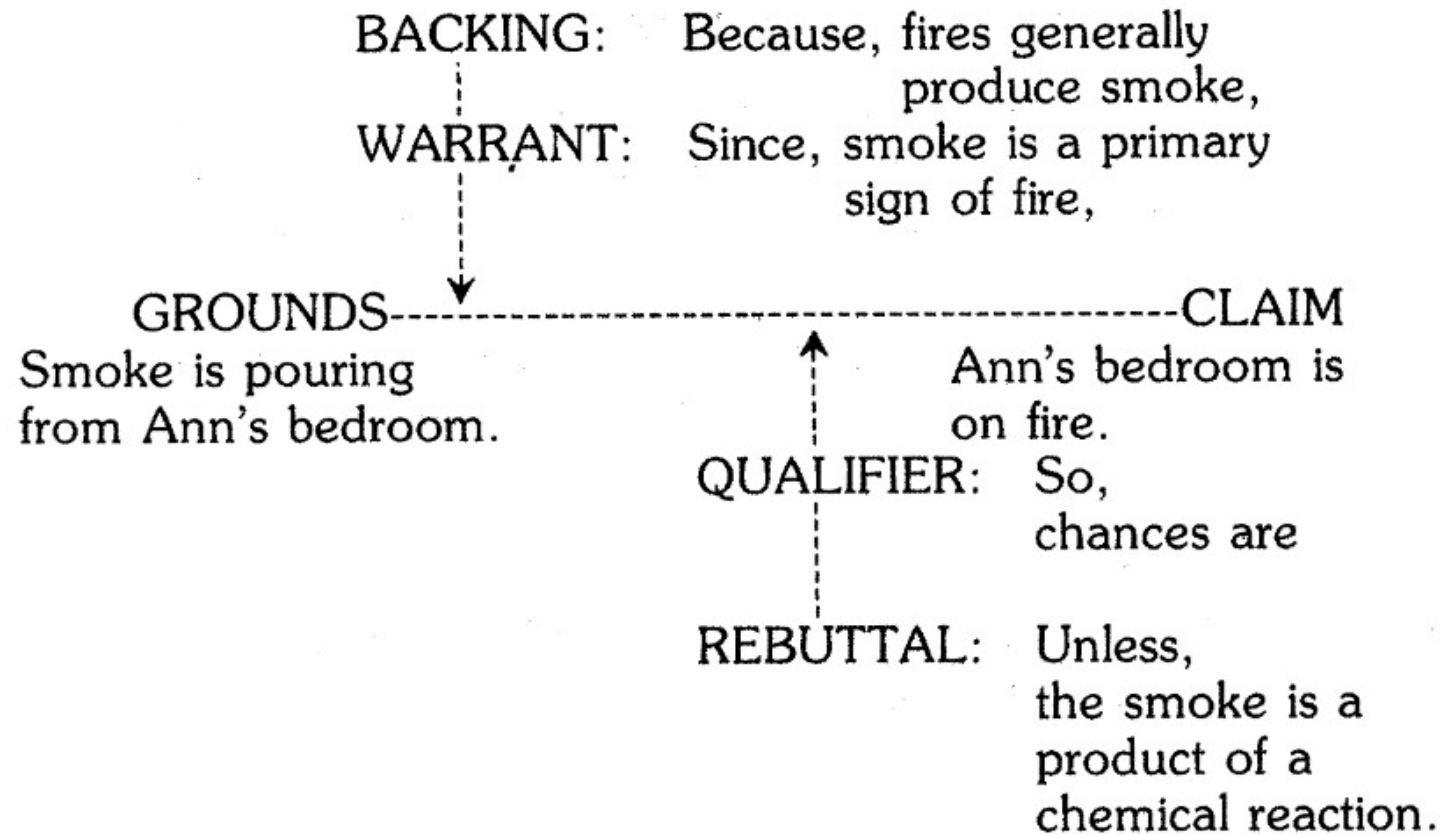
Claim: *Anna's bedroom is on fire.*

Rebuttal: *Unless the smoke is a product of a chemical reaction.*

Warrant: *Smoke is a primary sign of fire.*

Backing: *Because fires usually generate smoke.*

Example



Look at the sentence below:



- What backing has been provided for the warrant?
- Is the backing convincing? Could it be improved?
- Has the claim been qualified? If so, how?
- What 'rebuttal' has been given. Can you think of any other rebuttals?

Research shows that living in an urban area with green spaces has a long-lasting positive impact on people's mental well-being. Around 47% of London is green space making London a great city to live in for many people. Having said that, London is also very crowded with roughly 14,500 people per square mile.

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The backing would be more convincing if there was a reference to the research so that we could check if the research was credible.

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Your turn



Update one of your examples by adding backing, a qualifier and a rebuttal and then share with your group.

- Is social media harmful?
- Have we achieved gender inclusivity and equality?
- Should we be concerned about falling birth rates in some countries?

Example:



Social media can be harmful (CLAIM)

because it can be detrimental for your mental health. (GROUND)

For example, Smith shows...(2024) (BACKING)

However, mental health is impacted more by other factors (REBUTTAL)



Use Toulmin to evaluate the strength of an argument in a paragraph



1. What is the **claim**?
2. What are the **grounds**? Are they true/believable?
3. What is the **warrant** (i.e. what links the claim and the grounds)? Is the warrant explicit or implicit? Do you agree with the warrant?

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Use Toulmin to evaluate the strength of an argument in a paragraph



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The warrant is implied and is the idea that econometric analysis, which uses statistical and mathematical models to develop theories or test existing hypotheses is an appropriate way to evaluate whether geography or institutions are more important. (Rodrik et al 2005: 527-528).

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No, there is no backing – you can judge whether it would have been helpful.

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Assignment



Look at the argumentation in your assignment, or in one of your Reading into Writing essays.

- What claims are you making?
- What grounds (evidence) do you have for your claims? Are your grounds convincing or can you improve them?
- Do you need to qualify your claims?
- What is your warrant (the link between your grounds and your claims)? Is your warrant explicit? Does it need to be?
- Does your warrant need any backing?
- Have you considered rebuttals to your claims? Do you need to?

Share with a partner.